The Manifesto and the End of Plural Marriage

The Belief Files

Case File 011

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | Prepared for Jamie Dennis | November 8, 2026

Investigation summary

In 1890, Wilford Woodruff issued a public declaration about plural marriage and obedience to law. In 1904, Joseph F. Smith issued another statement prohibiting new plural marriages and attaching the possibility of excommunication. The interval between them is essential to understanding what it meant for the practice to end. [3,7]

This case examines the declarations, Woodruff's journal and explanations, federal legal action, and selected passages of Smith's Senate testimony. It asks what was promised publicly, what conduct continued, and how religious authority was used to explain the transition. It does not treat a new marriage, continued marital relations, financial support, and an eternal sealing as the same event.

The historical conclusion is that ending plural marriage was a process involving changed instructions, disputed applications, and later enforcement. The theological question is whether that process demonstrates divine guidance, human accommodation, or some combination of sincere conviction and institutional adjustment. The existence of pressure alone cannot decide the answer.

The claim under investigation

The LDS interpretation is that the authority which introduced plural marriage could also suspend or end its practice by revelation. Official Declaration 1 presents Woodruff's declaration as authoritative; its accompanying addresses describe divine direction in response to threats against the Church and its temples. [3]

The modern Church essay acknowledges new plural marriages after 1890 in Mexico, Canada, and some U.S. settings. It describes approval at times by individual First Presidency members, without definitive evidence of collective First Presidency decisions. It also recognizes that a cited marriage ledger is incomplete. These admissions make the transition more complicated than either an immediate universal stop or a claim that all later unions were wholly unconnected with leaders. [2]

The investigation therefore tests several propositions separately: what the 1890 document actually said; whether new unions continued; whether existing spouses retained obligations; and what changed when the 1904 declaration expressly added discipline. The same evidence may support one proposition while leaving another unresolved.

How this investigation weighs evidence

The text of a declaration is primary evidence for its wording. It is not, by itself, a complete record of compliance. A journal can show the writer's stated purpose and belief without independently verifying the source of an inspiration. Sworn testimony deserves scrutiny both for what is admitted and for how terms are defined.

In this record, the word Church can refer to the institution acting through authorized collective procedures, or more loosely to its leaders and members. A denial of action by the first does not automatically deny every action by the second. The distinction may be formally meaningful while still leaving a serious question about what an ordinary audience would understand.

This is an examination of selected documents and passages, not a review of all four volumes of the Smoot proceedings or a new audit of every post-Manifesto marriage. Where an institutional essay reports archival research, that report is identified as such rather than presented as our own examination of the underlying ledger.

The historical timeline

Date	Evidence or development	What needs distinguishing
March 22, 1882	The Edmunds Act adds an unlawful-cohabitation offense.	An ongoing relationship from a new marriage ceremony. [4]
March 3, 1887	The Edmunds-Tucker Act targets Church corporate and property arrangements.	The enacted provisions from a general claim that all private property was seized. [5]
May 1890	The Supreme Court upholds the central disincorporation and property action.	A historical legal holding from a verdict about revelation. [5]
September 24-25, 1890	The Manifesto is dated September 24 and publicly released September 25.	The document date from publication and later acceptance. [3,6]
October 6, 1890	General conference accepts the Manifesto as authoritative and binding.	An institutional vote from universal private understanding. [3]
1890-1904	Some new plural marriages and existing plural relationships continue.	New unions, marital cohabitation, and material support. [2,8]
March-April 1904	Smith testifies before the Senate and issues the Second Manifesto on April 6.	Testimony about existing families from the new disciplinary declaration. [7–8]

Date	Evidence or development	What needs distinguishing
Following years	Discipline is applied to resistance, including apostles Taylor and Cowley.	A later enforcement process from an instantaneous result in April 1904. [2]

Exhibit one The pressure and Woodruff's response

Law changed the practical choices

The 1882 statute separately prohibited a man's cohabitation with more than one woman in a federal territory. This reduced the importance of proving a particular marriage ceremony to every prosecution. Its civic restrictions also made the conflict more than a private dispute about family arrangements. [4]

The 1890 Supreme Court decision in Late Corporation of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints v. United States addressed the federal dissolution of the Church corporation and the disposition of property. The opinion reproduces relevant legislation, including the 1887 act, and sustains the central federal action. This is documentary evidence of an institutional threat, not merely a later Church explanation of one. [5]

The decision needs to be stated with its limits. A statutory action against a corporation and specified property does not mean every member's possessions were automatically confiscated. Nor does the Court's approval establish that federal policy was morally wise in every consequence. This case cites historical law, not present-day legal advice.

The journal records both necessity and inspiration

Woodruff's September 25, 1890 journal explicitly connects the proclamation with the Church's temporal survival. It also describes prayer and the inspiration he believed he received. These belong in the same account: institutional necessity was not an invention imposed on the record by later critics, and Woodruff did not describe his action solely as a secular calculation. [6]

That combination allows more than one interpretation. A believer may see God guiding a president through an urgent practical crisis. A critic may see a religious interpretation attached to an institution's necessary adaptation. The journal supports the existence of the pressure and Woodruff's stated conviction; it cannot independently verify which interpretation is correct.

The source's day-page includes editorial summaries as well as the transcribed entry. Those surrounding items should not override the dated declaration and conference record. In particular, the authoritative acceptance occurred in October 1890, not a year later. [3,6]

Read the later explanation as a later explanation

Addresses appended to Official Declaration 1 discuss the danger of losing temples, stopping ordinances, and imprisoning leaders. Woodruff says he would have accepted those losses if God had required it, but that God directed a different course. This is a direct claim of revelation, not merely a recommendation that members become more practical. [3]

The appended addresses have their own occasions and dates. They should not be quoted as if every explanatory sentence appeared in the original September proclamation. The October 6, 1890 assurance about a president not leading the Church astray and the subsequent discussion of the threatened losses are part of the evidentiary record, but not all part of one document composed at one moment.

Exhibit two What the first Manifesto said

The declaration begins by responding to reports about ongoing plural marriages and public encouragement of the practice. Woodruff denies the charges in specified terms, including ceremonies in temples or elsewhere in the territory during the period addressed. He then declares his intention to submit to the laws and influence Church members to do likewise. [3]

Its closing advice is to refrain from contracting a marriage forbidden by the law of the land. That wording concerns entering marriages, while the opening passages address what the Church was teaching and permitting. The whole text matters; it is inaccurate to reduce it to either an unconditional

statement about every existing relationship or a private opinion with no institutional weight.

Lorenzo Snow's motion at the October conference identifies the declaration as dated September 24, 1890 and asks the Church to accept it as authoritative and binding. Woodruff's journal and the publication history place the public release on September 25. The dates describe different stages rather than competing dates for one event. [3,6]

The proclamation does not explain in detail how every existing plural household should organize its life. Silence on those details is historically important. It does not automatically authorize any particular later conduct; it means that later instructions, testimony, and actions must be examined instead of read back into an unwritten paragraph.

Exhibit three What continued after 1890

Four different questions

Activity	The question to investigate	Why it matters
A new plural marriage	Was another wife added, and who approved or performed the ceremony?	This directly concerns entering a new union.
Continued marital relations	Did an existing couple continue living as spouses, including sexual relations?	This could violate cohabitation law without a new marriage.
Financial and parental support	Were existing wives and children provided for?	Material responsibility does not by itself prove continued marital relations.
A religious sealing claim	What relationship was asserted to endure beyond death?	Religious status and an observable new household are distinct categories.

This framework prevents two common errors. Evidence that a husband continued supporting a wife is not automatically proof of a new marriage. Evidence that he continued fathering children with an existing wife is not merely evidence that he paid her bills. A claim should be matched to the conduct actually documented.

New unions and the question of approval

The modern essay's acknowledgment of post-1890 unions requires a careful account of authorization. Approval by an individual leader is not identical to a formal collective decision. It is nevertheless relevant to whether the public could reasonably believe that the institution's own senior authorities had ceased facilitating new unions. [2]

We should not turn a limited ledger into a complete census or assume that its unrecorded marriages did not occur. Conversely, a historian's identification of additional unions does not establish that every marriage in a sealing register was plural. The present investigation relies on the essay's qualified report and does not supply a new total.

The fact that a marriage took place outside U.S. jurisdiction also does not prove that it was lawful where performed. Jurisdiction, enforcement, and legality are different questions. A claim about compliance in Mexico or Canada needs the relevant local law and circumstances, not simply a map showing that the location was outside Utah.

Existing families and the Senate testimony

In March 1904, Joseph F. Smith testified in the proceedings concerning Senator Reed Smoot's right to his seat. Selected passages show Smith acknowledging continued relations with his wives and the birth of children after the Manifesto. He presented his conduct as fidelity to existing family obligations and acknowledged the problem under the law. [8]

The exchange on printed pages 130-131 is particularly instructive. The examiner distinguishes providing homes and supporting children from continued sexual relations. Smith resists treating those relationships as something he could simply abandon. The disagreement is therefore not

solved by saying that critics wanted children left without financial support; the questioning itself separates those issues.

On printed pages 196-197, a broad answer about obeying law is challenged with a specific question about his five wives and children born since 1890. Smith then qualifies the general answer: he was not claiming compliance in that particular respect. That qualification matters when assessing both his candor and the possible impression made by the broader statement. [8]

The testimony documents existing plural relations. It must not be transformed into an admission that Smith married eleven additional wives, or that every child mentioned resulted from a new post-1890 marriage. Neither follows from the exchange.

Smoot himself was a monogamist. The institutional loyalty controversy surrounding an apostle in the Senate should not be confused with a claim that he personally had plural wives. Nor should the Smoot proceedings be merged with the separate congressional controversy involving B. H. Roberts. [2,9]

Exhibit four The Second Manifesto

On April 6, 1904, Smith presented an official statement at general conference. It denies that prohibited marriages had been solemnized with the Church's sanction, consent, or knowledge, and then announces that such marriages are prohibited. It specifies that a member or officer entering or solemnizing one could face Church proceedings and excommunication. [7]

The declaration's denial needs the same definitional scrutiny as the Senate testimony. If Church means an institution acting collectively, the sentence is narrower than a claim that no senior leader had ever known of or individually approved a union. If an audience heard the broader claim, the distinction could obscure relevant conduct. The investigator should state the distinction rather than assume that the formal wording resolves every question of public honesty.

The disciplinary provision is also consequential. It sets out what will happen to people who continue entering or performing the prohibited marriages.

Calling the second declaration merely an unnecessary repetition misses that practical feature. Calling it proof that the 1890 statement had no importance misses the earlier public commitment and conference acceptance.

The published 1904 statement refers to the earlier Manifesto with a September 26 date. That is the wording of the later historical document; the 1890 conference motion identifies the original as dated September 24, with public release on September 25. A source register should preserve the discrepancy instead of silently making every source say the same date. [3,6–7]

Enforcement still required action. The current Church account describes Taylor and Cowley's removal from the Twelve and later discipline: Taylor's excommunication and restriction of Cowley's priesthood functions. These should not be compressed into a claim that both were excommunicated immediately in April 1904. [2]

The present Church's prohibition also needs to be distinguished from the beliefs and practices of separate fundamentalist groups. Historical continuity claims made by those groups do not make them interchangeable with the contemporary Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. [10]

Assessing the principal accounts

Witness group	What the evidence supports	What it does not establish
Woodruff's journal and addresses	His stated practical concerns and claimed divine guidance. [3,6]	Independent observation of the divine source of that guidance.
The 1890 declaration and conference action	A public commitment and formal acceptance. [3]	Immediate uniform compliance or a complete household policy.
Smith's Senate testimony	Admissions and qualifications concerning his existing relationships. [8]	A complete inventory of all later marriages or every leader's knowledge.

Witness group	What the evidence supports	What it does not establish
The 1904 declaration	Express prohibition and the possibility of excommunication. [7]	That resistance and enforcement ended on the day of the vote.
The modern institutional history	Qualified acknowledgment of continued unions and later discipline. [2]	Our own inspection of each underlying archival record.

The documents should be compared by date and purpose. A later explanation may clarify a policy, but it can also narrow how an earlier public statement is understood. Both possibilities deserve examination. The goal is to establish what the evidence supports, not to make all apparent tensions disappear through a definition supplied after the event.

The strongest LDS argument

A strong faithful account accepts that the transition was difficult and uneven. It understands revelation as responsive to circumstances and emphasizes obligations to existing spouses and children. The same God who commanded a practice could release people from the obligation to begin new unions without making earlier sincere obedience fraudulent. [3,6–7]

This argument does not depend on proving that all institutional adaptation is corrupt. Religious bodies routinely distinguish enduring convictions from changing applications. A divine command to act at one time and cease at another is not a logical contradiction simply because the dates differ.

The unresolved questions concern the evidence for those commands, the clarity of public assurances, and the relationship between official declarations and senior leaders' conduct. A change described as revelation must still be tested. The claim that a president cannot lead the Church astray is part of the claim under investigation; it cannot serve as its independent proof.

Competing explanations

Divine direction through changing circumstances. This fits Woodruff's stated conviction and the faithful interpretation of the conference actions. It requires reasons to identify the guidance as divine beyond the declaration of the person whose authority is being assessed.

Sincere religious accommodation to institutional danger. A president could genuinely pray, believe he was inspired, and also respond to a threat that made the previous course unsustainable. This explains why religious language and practical necessity appear together without requiring a secret confession of unbelief.

Public reassurance with restricted private exceptions. This highlights the tension between broad public language and the continuation of some new unions. It requires marriage-specific evidence of approval and knowledge; one should not assume identical arrangements for every ceremony.

A uniformly fraudulent performance by every leader and participant. This goes beyond the sources examined. Inconsistency, caution, and self-protective language justify scrutiny, but do not establish the private unbelief of every person involved.

The first three explanations can account for overlapping portions of the evidence. Choosing among them requires a stated standard for revelation and institutional truthfulness, not merely a preference for a favorable or unfavorable label.

Motives benefits and costs

Institutional survival was an acknowledged motive. Retaining temples, keeping leaders available, and reducing legal conflict were real benefits. Those incentives deserve examination because they could influence the timing and wording of a declaration. They do not, by themselves, prove a consciously false spiritual claim. [3,6]

Existing families had other interests. A wife might fear abandonment; a husband might understand continued relations as a covenant obligation.

Those concerns can be sincere while still failing to answer whether particular conduct complied with law or matched public assurances. Emotional significance is relevant evidence, not exemption from analysis.

Government officials and political opponents also had interests: enforcing law, defining the conditions of statehood, and obtaining public support. The moral legitimacy of every enforcement measure cannot be inferred solely from its success. A fair investigation can question governmental coercion and religious evasiveness within the same history.

A biblical assessment

A changing instruction requires a defensible authority

The Bible contains distinct instructions for different circumstances, so change alone is not a sufficient test of falsity. The question is whether a claimed messenger has authority to give the particular command and whether its content is consistent with God's revealed truth. Galatians 1:6-9 and 1 John 4:1 require examination rather than automatic acceptance of religious claims. [11]

From the evangelical perspective of this series, a claim to restored authority does not establish itself by an institutional vote or by survival after a crisis. The reasoning must not become circular: the leader is true because his revelation says he is protected from error, and the revelation is true because that leader issued it.

Words and conduct belong together

Matthew 5:33-37 gives weight to truthful speech, and Ephesians 4:25 calls believers to put away falsehood. These texts ask more than whether a statement can be defended under the narrowest possible definition. The practical question includes whether the listener was being given a truthful understanding of the relevant conduct. [12]

We should apply that standard to Christian institutions as well. A church can accurately deny a formal corporate decision while failing to disclose significant actions by its own leaders. The legal distinction may matter, but

Christian truthfulness also requires attention to what the public assurance communicates.

Support is a duty rather than a debating device

First Timothy 5:8 makes household provision a serious responsibility. It does not establish that every form of continued marital relation is necessary to discharge that responsibility. Conversely, a decision to stop a prohibited arrangement cannot be used as an excuse to abandon dependents. [13]

The testimony's distinction between provision and sexual relations is therefore ethically relevant. A Christian evaluation should be concrete about duties and avoid using women and children merely as rhetorical protection for a leader's decisions.

Obedience to God must be tested

Acts 5:29 and Romans 13:1-7 show why the conflict between religion and law cannot be reduced to an automatic slogan. The first does not authenticate every act of religious civil disobedience; the second does not make every governmental demand righteous. Establishing the claimed divine command remains necessary. [14]

The Christian witness finally points to Christ, whose saving sufficiency is not dependent on accepting each successive marital instruction of a later institution. Hebrews 7:23-28 and Ephesians 2:8-10 anchor that assessment in Christ's priesthood and God's grace. This is the theological conclusion of the series, stated as such rather than disguised as a fact proved by a Senate transcript. [15]

Findings and confidence

Finding	Confidence	Basis or limit
The 1890 Manifesto made a public commitment regarding forbidden new marriages.	High	Declaration and conference acceptance. [3]
Woodruff connected his action with both institutional survival and inspiration.	High	His journal and appended explanations. [3,6]
Some new plural marriages continued after 1890.	High, with limits on totals and approval	Acknowledged in the official historical account; no new archival census claimed. [2]
Smith continued relations in existing plural marriages after 1890.	High	His own selected Senate testimony. [8]
The 1904 statement expressly linked prohibited new unions with Church discipline.	High	Published conference declaration. [7]
Political pressure independently proves that every revelation claim was knowingly false.	Not established	Motive and circumstance do not supply access to every person's private belief.

Overall assessment

The record does not support an uncomplicated story in which all plural marriage ended in September 1890. Neither does it support treating the Manifesto as irrelevant. It was a consequential public and religious declaration whose application developed through a difficult interval, followed by a more explicit prohibition and enforcement.

For a Christian evaluating authority, the principal concerns are the basis for claiming divine direction and the adequacy of public truthfulness when conduct and definitions diverged. The strongest faithful explanation deserves a fair hearing; it does not remove the need for independent evaluation.

The appropriate conclusion is specific: the transition is historically documented, its divine source is not independently established by those documents, and the relation between institutional declarations and leaders' actions warrants direct questions. Modern LDS members should be invited into that examination without being assigned personal blame for decisions made before they were born.

Read compare and discuss

1. What did the 1890 declaration expressly promise? Which practical questions did it leave unexplained?
2. Why should the document date, public release, and conference acceptance remain separate?
3. How would you distinguish a new union, continued marital relations, financial support, and a sealing claim?
4. Read the cited Senate exchanges. Where does Smith qualify a broad statement with a narrower explanation?
5. When does a technical institutional distinction help an audience understand, and when might it obscure relevant facts?
6. What did the 1904 declaration add in practical terms?
7. Why does political pressure neither prove revelation nor automatically disprove sincere belief?
8. What standard of truthful public speech would you apply equally to a Christian church and an LDS institution?

Accuracy notes and further research

The supplied research packet provides the starting framework; original declarations and selected testimony supply the principal checks. This investigation does not claim a complete review of the Smoot hearings, every foreign jurisdiction's law, or the original marriage ledger cited by the modern essay. [1–8]

Do not equate support with sexual cohabitation, or cohabitation with entering a new marriage. Do not call Smoot a polygamist. Do not count all ledger sealings as plural unions, treat an incomplete ledger as exhaustive, or characterize individual approval as necessarily a collective First Presidency decision.

The institutional distinctions do not pre-decide whether the public was adequately informed. Equally, a discrepancy does not grant access to an individual's private belief. Further work should compare specific marriage records, permission correspondence, contemporary public assurances, and the full disciplinary files, while preserving the date and purpose of each.

Sources and reading

[1] Jamie Dennis, supplied LDS Gospel Topics Essays research compilation, Manifesto packet, physical PDF pages 242-252. Starting research framework, checked against the identified records below.

[2] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, "The Manifesto and the End of Plural Marriage," Gospel Topics Essays. Institutional account, including qualified reports of continued unions, approval, ledger limitations, and later discipline. The original ledger and full disciplinary files were not independently audited here. Open source

[3] Official Declaration 1, Doctrine and Covenants. Manifesto; Lorenzo Snow's October 6, 1890 motion; separately dated excerpts from Woodruff's addresses. Open source

[4] Edmunds Act, March 22, 1882, ch. 47, 22 Stat. 30-32, especially section 3. Historical statutory transcription. Open source

[5] Late Corporation of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints v. United States, 136 U.S. 1 (1890). Primary court opinion and reproduced statutory provisions, including the Edmunds-Tucker Act, March 3, 1887, ch. 397, 24 Stat. 635. Court text reproduced by Justia; the decision is used as historical law. Open source

[6] Wilford Woodruff, journal, September 25, 1890, transcribed by the Wilford Woodruff Papers. The entry's statement of practical necessity and inspiration is distinguished from surrounding editorial event summaries. Open source

[7] Joseph F. Smith, "Official Statement," April 6, 1904, Seventy-Fourth Annual Conference Report, printed pages 75-76. Statement and endorsement proceedings, transcribed at Wikisource from the published report. Its September 26 reference to the earlier Manifesto is preserved as a documentary discrepancy. Open source

[8] U.S. Senate, Proceedings before the Committee on Privileges and Elections in the Matter of the Protests against the Right of Hon. Reed Smoot, vol. 1 (Government Printing Office, 1904). Selected Joseph F. Smith exchanges on printed pages 130-131 and 196-197 consulted in the digitized full-text record; not a review of all volumes. Open source

[9] McKay Library Special Collections, Brigham Young University-Idaho, "1904 Statement on Plural Marriage." Context and links to the original conference report; distinguishes Smoot's monogamy. Open source

[10] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, "Plural Marriage and Families in Early Utah," introductory statement of the contemporary prohibition. The modern Church and separate fundamentalist groups must not be conflated. Open source

[11] Galatians 1:6-9; 1 John 4:1. KJV. Standards for examining claims about religious authority and revelation.

[12] Matthew 5:33-37; Ephesians 4:25. KJV. Truthful words and conduct.

[13] 1 Timothy 5:8. KJV. Material responsibility for a household.

[14] Acts 5:29; Romans 13:1-7. KJV. Obedience to God and civil authority, with attention to each passage's context.

[15] Hebrews 7:23-28; Ephesians 2:8-10. KJV. Christ's priesthood and the evangelical understanding of salvation by grace.